

Justification



A gavel has come down on the block. The sound is the point. A court has spoken. The defendant does not leave “mostly improved.” The defendant leaves with a verdict.

Before you gather

- Read Day 15, Justification, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Romans 4:4–8 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.

- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.
- Leave with a name. The missional challenge only works if someone is named before you pray.

1 · ICEBREAKER · 7 MIN

Open the room

Have you ever been cleared of something people assumed you had done?
What changed when the verdict was read?

Leader. A verdict changes your standing in a moment. Then open Romans 4. God counts righteousness apart from works. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 · THE WORD · 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: Justification means God declares sinners righteous as a gift, because of Jesus, through faith. It is a verdict, not a process.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Justification is the judicial act of God in which He declares sinners righteous in His sight, not on the basis of their works, but solely on the basis of Christ's righteousness imputed to them and received by faith alone.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek *dikaioō* — to declare righteous. A verdict, not a process of self-improvement.

MEMORY VERSE · ROMANS 3:24

And are justified by his grace as a gift, through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus.

Together, open the flashcard for Justification. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

Romans 4:4–8

Romans 3:24 is the memory verse. Stay in Romans 4:4–8. Paul uses Abraham and David so no one can turn justification into self-improvement.

Now to the one who works, his wages are not counted as a gift but as his due. And to the one who does not work but believes in him who justifies the ungodly, his faith is counted as righteousness, just as David also speaks of the blessing of the one to whom God counts righteousness apart from works: “Blessed are those whose lawless deeds are forgiven, and whose sins are covered; blessed is the man against whom the Lord will not count his sin.”

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. Romans 4:4–5 sets wages against a gift. What does God justify, and what does the person do? CORE

Leader. God justifies the ungodly. The person believes. Faith is counted as righteousness. Wages are what you earn. The gospel is not wages.

2. David says, “Blessed is the man against whom the Lord will not count his sin.” Whose counting matters?

Leader. The Lord's. Not the room's opinion. Not the person's memory of failure. God does not count sin against the one He justifies.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. How is justification different from sanctification? Use one sentence a new believer could repeat.

Leader. Justification is God declaring you righteous now, by faith in Christ. Sanctification is God making you holy over time. Do not mix them.

4. If someone says, “God helps those who help themselves,” what does Romans 4:5 answer? CORE

Leader. God justifies the ungodly. He does not wait for us to become godly and then declare it. Jesus came to die for the ungodly.

5. 2 Corinthians 5:21: God made Christ who knew no sin to be sin, so that in Him we become the righteousness of God. Who is the substitute?

Leader. Christ. Our sin is counted to Him. His righteousness is counted to us. That is the great exchange. Say it.

5 · SAY IT · 5 MIN

In one sentence

Justification means God declares sinners righteous as a gift, because of Jesus, received by faith.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 · THIS WEEK · 5 MIN

Missional challenge

Before next week, carry this word to someone far from Jesus — a neighbor, a classmate, a coworker, a friend. Do it with a real action and with a true sentence. Name the person before you pray.

Speak up for someone being summed up by their worst day. Then tell them God does not grade sinners up. He declares the ungodly righteous through faith in Jesus.

Leader. The action is a true word in their defense. The sentence has to stay a gift. Do not say “God knows your heart is basically good.” Next week, before the icebreaker, take one minute. Who went, and what happened? One sentence. No speeches.

Pray these, and leave room for others

1. Righteous God, thank You for a verdict we did not earn.
2. Forgive us for bringing You our wages and calling it faith.
3. Help us tell one ungodly friend that You justify those who trust Jesus.

Before you stumble

Do not let justification become “God makes you better and then accepts you.” Romans 4:5 will not allow it. Also do not say a person is justified who refuses to believe. Faith receives the gift. If someone is crushed by old sin, read verse 8 slowly. The Lord does not count it against them.

WITH STUDENTS

Use a gradebook if you must. Justification is not extra credit. It is Christ's perfect record written on their name, and the old page torn up. Then ask if that feels unfair. Say: the Someone else asked for it.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

Galatians 2:16. A person is not justified by works of the law but through faith in Jesus Christ. Read it and stop.